POINTS OF CONFLICT

The alliance with BJP has taken the sheen off Pawar's abrasive strongman image. A perception exists that Pawar and Co. capitulated to escape investigation by the central agencies



Ajit sets up parallel unit to review the progress of key infrastructure projects

Even Fadnavis admits that the NCP was not a natural ally. "The Shiv Sena is our natural ally...the NCP is our political ally. It has not become our natural ally so far as we have worked against each other for years. If we stay together for the next 10-20 years, it may become our natural ally," Fadnavis had said at the recent India Today Conclave in Mumbai. NCP leaders also admit that the arrangement is more of a "peace treaty" rather than an alliance or a coalition.

Significantly, while reports of the BJP changing horses midstream by replacing Shinde with Pawar surface regularly, Fadnavis stressed that the former would lead the coalition in the elections. "When Ajit *dada* has to be made (the CM), we will make him for the full five years... for now, let me tell you clearly, Shindeji is the chief minister and will remain so," said Fadnavis, adding that the Lok Sabha and state assembly elections would be fought under Shinde's leadership.

DESPITE SHINDE'S CLAIM THAT THE INCLUSION OF AJIT'S NCP HAS MADE IT A "TRIPLE-ENGINE" GOVERNMENT, THE ALLIES SEEM TO BE AT ODDS ON POLITICS AS WELL AS POLICY

Disqualification petitions against Shinde and his MLAs are pending with assembly speaker Rahul Narwekar. On October 20, the Supreme Court directed Narwekar to decide on these petitions by December 31. He has also been directed to rule on the disqualification petitions filed by the NCP camps by January 24, 2024.

Despite Shinde's claim that Ajit's inclusion has converted the "double-engine" government into a "triple-engine" one, the allies seem to be at odds with each other on politics as well as policy. While the CM's office has a war room to monitor the progress of big-ticket projects, Ajit has set up a parallel project management unit (PMU). He told reporters that his review was a way of speeding up work on these projects.

In August, the state government nixed a decision where stringent conditions had been imposed on six sugar cooperative mills controlled by BJP leaders for securing margin money loans worth Rs 539 crore from the National Cooperative Development Corporation (NCDC). It was Ajit who had imposed the additional conditions fixing the responsibility of the repayment on the directors. Embarrassingly, the government has also had to roll back a series of policy decisions. These include contractual recruitments to government jobs in October, a ban on farmers selling sugarcane to mills in other states in September, and the standardised uniform for the 6.4 million students in state-run schools in May.

Another point of conflict is over the distribution of the posts of district guardian ministers. In Raigad, Shinde's MLAs and even those from the BJP are resisting the plan to appoint women and child development minister Aditi Tatkare as the guardian minister. Aditi is the daughter of Ajit confidant and Raigad MP Sunil Tatkare. Shinde loyalist and Mahad MLA Bharatseth Gogawale did not see eye to eye with Aditi, who was also a minister of state in the earlier MVA (Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi) government. In Nashik, the NCP's food and civil supplies minister Chhagan Bhujbal is said to be eager to replace the Shinde Sena's Dadaji Bhuse.

Ajit has managed to wrest the position of Pune's guardian minister from the BJP's Chandrakant Patil, the minister for higher education. A tussle saw Ajit have his way on October 4. A clip of Patil purportedly telling party workers that this was a "small adjustment" for a larger cause is now making the rounds.

In government, though, a senior BJP leader says that Ajit's role has been circumscribed by Shinde, a far cry from the time when he ran the show as deputy to Uddhav Thackeray in the MVA government from November 2019 to June 2022. "Overall, Ajit's NCP faction is a good party to have on our side. Their ministers are experienced and have strong pockets of support in their constituencies and districts, which will help us in the Lok Sabha election," says the BJP leader. Also, says an Ajit confidant, unlike Shinde and his men, who were seen as *gaddars* (traitors) by hardcore Sainiks, no such sentiment exists against Ajit. His image as someone who can keep a check on the administration and get work done has also stood him in good stead.

That said, an NCP leader loyal to Sharad Pawar says that some party MLAs who had jumped ship with Ajit are feeling boxed in. The fact that the latter has delegated organisational roles to aides such as former Union minister Praful Patel and Tatkare is